THE MBA OF TODAY

- In India, there are at least 4,000 institutes offering an MBA
- With high fees, the starting salary must justify the money spent, to attract the best talent
- Five years ago, MBAs were hired for functional competence
- In today's times, decisions have to be taken in a very volatile and uncertain environment
- With Gen Z spoilt for choice in terms of opportunities, the big challenge is convincing them to do an MBA
- Organisations looking beyond B-schools for talent, to engineering and law colleges



in its current form, at least in more developed markets, is being seriously questioned.

The genesis of this paradigm shift can be traced back to the period before the Covid-19 pandemic, when digitalisation became the buzzword, and to the pandemic years, when lockdowns pushed practically everything online.

In mid-2019, the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign (a much sought-after place) announced that it was shutting its residential full-time and part-time MBA programmes to focus on an online MBA or iMBA. "The iMBA is the right format for the times – providing a powerful learning experience with anytime/anywhere accessibility at an affordable cost," the university said in a statement at that point.

A whiff of that storm is blowing towards India as well, which has around 4,000 institutes (includes universities, standalone institutes and colleges) offering the degree.

Alok Kumar Rai, Director of IIM Calcutta, says getting students to pursue a two-year MBA will become a challenge in India. "That will lead to greater emergence of the one-year degree. A key benefit is the duration being compressed," he says.

The one-year executive programme at his institute, and other top B-schools, stipulates prior work experience of about five years. This arrangement allowed students to save a year and helped them move up within their organisations. "Clearly, the one-year degree is the future and our curriculum needs to be reviewed from that perspective," adds Rai.

40%

OF THE TOP 25 B-SCHOOLS HAVE REPORTED LOWER ADMISSIONS THIS YEAR COMPARED TO LAST YEAR, INCLUDING THE FOUR IIMs